

⚡ ESSENTIAL SURVIVAL QUICK-REFERENCE

Sourced from: FM 3-05.70 · TC 4-02.1 · FEMA · CDC · NOAA · USGS · NRC | Public Domain

THE RULE OF THREES

3 min without air · 3 hrs without shelter (extreme cold) · 3 days without water · 3 weeks without food

💧 BLEEDING & TRAUMA

MARCH Protocol:

M – Massive hemorrhage: Tourniquet 2–3" above wound, tighten until bleeding stops, note time
A – Airway: Tilt head, lift chin. Unconscious → recovery position
R – Respiration: Seal chest wounds with palm, tape 3 sides
C – Circulation: Direct pressure on wounds, do NOT remove dressings
H – Hypothermia: Keep victim warm, off ground
Tourniquet: Never remove in field. Write application time on forehead or tourniquet.

💧 WATER

Priority order:

Running water over still; upstream from activity
Boil: Rolling boil 1 min (3 min at altitude >6,500 ft)
Bleach: 8 drops unscented per gallon, wait 30 min
Iodine: 5 drops per liter, wait 30 min (clear water)
Dehydration signs: dark urine, headache, confusion
Daily min: 1 qt/day survival, 2 qt/day activity
Never drink: seawater, urine, blood, alcohol, raw floodwater without treatment

🔥 FIRE

Fire Triangle: Heat + Fuel + Oxygen
Build order: Tinder → Kindling → Fuel (smallest to largest)
Methods (no lighter):
• **Bow drill:** dry softwood spindle on dry fireboard
• **Flint & steel:** strike at 30° toward tinder
• **Lens:** focus sunlight on dark tinder (sunny day)
Distress signal: 3 fires in triangle = international distress
In rain: build under canopy; use birch bark, pine resin, dry inner bark

🏠 SHELTER

Priority: Ground insulation > wind block > rain cover

Lean-to (fastest):

Ridge pole 7 ft between two trees
Lean branches at 45° angle
Layer debris shingle-style, top to bottom
4" debris on ground for insulation
Heat loss: 60% from head/neck — always cover
Ideal interior temp: above 60°F
Avoid: valley bottoms (cold air, flooding), lone tall trees (lightning), dry riverbeds (flash flood)

🧭 NAVIGATION

Map: Align map north with compass; adjust for magnetic declination
Pace count: Count LEFT foot strikes. ~100 paces = 100 m (varies by terrain)
Sun navigation:
• Sunrise = East / Sunset = West
• **Stick shadow:** mark tip, wait 15 min, mark again → line = E–W
• **Polaris:** end of Little Dipper's handle
Terrain: Ridge (elongated high), Draw (valley between ridges), Saddle (dip between peaks)
Lost? STOP: Stop · Think · Observe · Plan

⚡ WEATHER THREATS

Tornado:
WARNING = take cover NOW. Lowest floor, interior room, away from windows. Abandon mobile homes. Cover head/neck.
Lightning (30/30 rule):
Thunder within 30 sec of flash → seek shelter. Wait 30 min after last thunder. Avoid trees, hilltops, open fields, water, metal.
Flash Flood:
Never walk/drive through moving water. 6" knocks you down; 2 ft floats most vehicles. Move to high ground.
Extreme Heat:
Drink every 15–20 min. **Heat stroke:** hot DRY skin, confusion, no sweating → call 911, cool with ice/water immediately.

☢️ NUCLEAR / RADIATION

Get Inside · Stay Inside · Stay Tuned:

Within 10–15 min: find nearest solid building
Go to center of middle floor or basement
Stay 24 hrs minimum (radiation drops 80% in 24h)
Remove outer clothing outside; shower ASAP
Seal windows/doors with tape/plastic if possible
Monitor EAS (Emergency Alert System) radio
KI (Potassium Iodide): Only protects thyroid from radioactive iodine. Take only if directed by authorities.
Contamination sign: dirt/debris on skin/clothes from blast = potential fallout

🍄 FOOD & FORAGING

Edibility test (one part at a time):

Smell: sour/bitter = suspect
Skin contact: rub on wrist, wait 15 min
Lip contact: wait 3 min, check for burning
Tongue tip: wait 15 min
Chew small amount, spit, wait 8 hrs
Eat small amount, wait 8 hrs
Safe: Dandelion (all parts), cattail, pine needles (Vit C tea), acorns (leach tannins), clover
Avoid: Shiny berries, umbrella flowers, milky sap, beans/seeds in pods, fine hairs, bitter/soapy/almond taste
Hunting priority: Insects > fish > small mammals

📶 SIGNALING & RESCUE

Universal distress: 3 of anything — 3 shots, 3 whistle blasts, 3 fires
Ground-to-air signals:
• **V** = Need assistance
• **X** = Need medical help
• → = Traveling this direction
• 1 = All OK
Mirror signal: Aim reflected light at aircraft; flash S-O-S (3 short · 3 long · 3 short)
Visibility: Orange, yellow, red visible from aircraft
Stay near crash site or last known position — searchers look there first.
Cell phone: Even no service = can call 911. Text often works when voice fails.